EVALUATING THE OIKODESPOTĒS

In a conceptual structure predicated upon the distinction between day and night, light and dark, good and bad, all the absolute qualities that were noble and productive of life were attributed to the benefic planets, while the ignoble and destructive qualities were linked to the malefic planets. Here we see the stark contrast between Jupiter and Mars in the descriptions of character arising from the Master of the Nativity. Keep in mind that this is the baseline that is subject to many modifications due to other factors. The final step of this process is to evaluate the condition of the *Oikodespotēs* in order to judge the vitality, well-being, character, and length of life. Firmicus Maternus gave an extensive list of criteria by which to evaluate the Master of the Nativity:

> For if it [*Oikodespotēs*] possesses the sum of the whole nativity, and the decrees of the individual stars are allotted by it; which, if it is well posited in those signs in which it rejoices or in which it is exalted, or in its own domiciles, and the nativity was of its own sect, and it was not struck by a harmful aspect of the malefics, nor was it devoid of the protection of the benefic stars, it denotes all good things in accordance with the quality of its own nature, and whole number of years [of life]. But if it is impedited by the malefics or deserted by the benefics, all of its efficacy languishes in a debilitated [state].[22]

Embedded within the delineation texts are instructions to consider whether the *Oikodespotēs* belonged to the sect of the chart, occupied its own domiciles or exaltation, was located in angular or succedent houses, and was rising. If so, it gave good character in accordance with its nature, and overall success by means of the things it signified.

Sect was an especially important factor in the evaluation of an *Oikodespotēs*. Near the end of the description of Mars are the following statements:

> For generally, it is necessary to notice that the benefic stars lessen their good deeds when operating contrary to the sect of the chart, while the destructive stars, in their own domiciles and belonging to the sect of the chart, bring forth activity that is dangerous and malignant along with harm. But, the malefic stars when in the places of the opposite sect and acting according to sect are more difficult with respect to harm. And whatever stars happen to be in ineffective signs or setting under the beams, having been found as lords (*Kurios*) or

22 FIRMICUS, *Mathesis* 4.6.1, trans. HOLDEN.